

Daily Sports Review — April 23, 2026

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Top Headlines

- Football Focus to end after 52 years
- No Fifa plan for Italy to replace Iran at World Cup
- Venus Williams loses 10th straight singles match
- Leicester 'face £70m black hole' after disastrous football-on-credit-card gamble
- Lamine Yamal season over but Spain star should make World Cup

FOOTBALL

Football Focus to end after 52 years

Football Focus is to end after 52 years, BBC Sport has announced. Launched in 1974, the Saturday lunchtime television programme provided fans with interviews, analysis and stories from across the game before the weekend's fixtures. Changing audience habits have meant a growth in the use of digital platforms and on-demand to get the same pre-match content.

Sourc

No Fifa plan for Italy to replace Iran at World Cup

Fifa has no plans to replace Iran with Italy at this summer's World Cup according to sources, after the switch was proposed by US president Donald Trump's special envoy. There has been ongoing uncertainty over Iran's participation in the tournament because of the war with US and Israel. US special envoy Paolo Zampolli told the Financial Times, external: "I confirm I have suggested to Trump and Infantino that Italy replace Iran at the World Cup."

Sourc

Leicester 'face £70m black hole' after disastrous football-on-credit-card gamble

From the outside it might seem difficult to understand quite how the Foxes got here. Leicester have been relegated despite having several of the highest-paid players in the Championship. Even the six-point deduction for failing financial rules in 2023-24 may not mathematically send them down, after just two wins from 19 league games in 2026.

Sourc

Lamine Yamal season over but Spain star should make World Cup

Spain forward Lamine Yamal will miss the remainder of Barcelona's season but is expected to be fit in time for the World Cup. The 18-year-old sustained a hamstring injury in his left leg during Wednesday's 1-0 victory over Celta Vigo. He had given Barcelona the lead from the penalty spot in the 40th minute but then immediately signalled to the bench before falling to the ground, clutching his left hamstring.

Sourc

Chelsea sack coach Rosenior amid historic slump

Chelsea have sacked head coach Liam Rosenior after less than four months in charge, the club announced on Wednesday.

Sourc

European football: Lamine Yamal's Barcelona season over but he should be fit for World Cup

Forward injured left hamstring against Celta VigoPSG stay in Ligue 1 title hunt with victory over NantesLamine Yamal will miss the rest of Barcelona's season with a hamstring injury but is expected to be available for Spain at the World Cup, his club said on Thursday. The 18-year-old limped off during Wednesday's 1-0 league win over Celta Vigo after scoring the only goal from the penalty spot. "The tests carried out have confirmed that first-team player Lamine Yamal has a hamstring injury in his."

Sourc

Churning Chelsea threw Rosenior in at the deep end but left him out of his depth | Jacob Steinberg

Daily Sports Press Review

Decision to hire an inexperienced manager has backfired badly and club's owners will have to reassess their approach There was symbolism to the Chelsea project reaching a reckoning at the Amex Stadium. Behdad Eghbali, one of the club's co-owners, looked ashen-faced in the directors' box. Enzo Fernández stared into the distance.

Italian sports minister dismisses plan for Azzurri to replace Iran at 2026 World Cup

Special envoy to Donald Trump suggested the idea 'Firstly not possible ... secondly not appropriate' The Italian sports minister, Andrea Abodi, has described a proposal for his country to replace Iran at the World Cup as "not appropriate", rejecting any idea that the Azzurri will be granted a last-minute berth at this summer's tournament. On Wednesday it emerged that Paolo Zampolli, a special envoy to Donald Trump, had suggested Italy should be fast-tracked to the World Cup despite their shock defeat by...

Rochdale showdown to East Grinstead woe: non-league stories you may have missed

Roundup of the promotion, playoff and relegation battles to be decided going into the final games of the season Emmanuel Dieseruvwe's 99th-minute winner for Rochdale against Braintree Town last week was a showbiz ending to a game that set up a showbiz ending to the season: the victory means Dale go into the final day with a chance of winning the National League and sealing the one automatic promotion spot, and they are hosting the only team above them, York City, who lead by two points....

Sources: Barça's León in talks over LCL transfer

Barcelona defender Mapi León is in talks with London City Lionesses over a potential free transfer when her contract expires this summer, sources have confirmed to ESPN.

TENNIS

Venus Williams loses 10th straight singles match

Source

Former world number one Venus Williams lost her 10th singles match in a row as she was beaten 6-2 6-4 by Kaitlin Quevedo at the Madrid Open. Williams, 45, is the first former number one to lose 10 matches in a row since the rankings were first published in 1975. The veteran last won a match last July when beating fellow American Peyton Stearns at the Washington Open.

Injured Draper to miss Madrid and Rome tournaments

Source

The 2024 US Open semi-finalist retired from his first round match in Barcelona when trailing Tomas Martin Etcheverry 4-1 in the deciding set. Struggling with his movement, the physio had applied tape to an area below his right knee before the final set began. He also wore tape on the knee at times in Indian Wells in early March, where he beat Novak Djokovic en route to the quarter-finals.

Injured Alcaraz & Djokovic pull out of Madrid Open

Source

Carlos Alcaraz and Novak Djokovic have withdrawn from next week's Madrid Open as their clay-court preparations for next month's French Open continue to be disrupted by injury. World number two Alcaraz is struggling with a wrist problem and the 22-year-old Spaniard was forced to pull out of this week's Barcelona Open with the issue. Alcaraz said delivering the news he was unable to participate in the tournament in Madrid, which is due to start on 21 April, was "incredibly difficult".

Joyce set for Six Nations comeback five months after giving birth

Source

Alisha Joyce is set for her Wales comeback just five months after giving birth to her son Ralphie. Joyce is named among the replacements to face reigning world and Six Nations champions England at Ashton Gate on Saturday (14:15 BST), 562 days since she and her partner Jaz Joyce last played together for Wales. The 28-year-old Bristol Bears flanker has only had half an hour of rugby in the Celtic Challenge this season.

CRICKET

Pietersen criticises Cook for Bethell comments

Kevin Pietersen has rekindled an old feud with Sir Alastair Cook by defending Jacob Bethell's continued presence at the Indian Premier League (IPL). England batter Bethell, who made a breakthrough century in the final Ashes Test in January, is yet to feature for Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) in this year's IPL. "He's not doing anything," Cook said on the Stick to Cricket podcast.

Sourc

FORMULA 1

How Russell is surprising himself in F1 title race

Sourc

George Russell has had to wait four years longer than he expected for this, and now his first shot at the Formula 1 world title has finally come, he says the way he feels about it is unexpected. As fate would have it, the location for our interview has brought Russell full circle. On a glorious spring evening at Silverstone on Wednesday, the Mercedes driver is officially opening the British Grand Prix track's new karting centre.

GENERAL

Over-75s drive levels of physical activity in England to record high but inequalities remain

Sourc

30m adults hitting 150 minutes moderate activity a week But report shows progress not being felt equally Levels of physical activity in England have broken new records, with more than 30 million adults now meeting the recommended 150 minutes of moderate activity a week, the latest Active Lives survey has revealed. The 10th edition of the gold standard report finds a striking rise in activity among older people with 11% growth among the over-75s in the past decade. There is also a consistent...